

The Marlow Lighthouse: A Short History

The Marlow Lighthouse was completed in 1874 on the granite headland north of Marlow harbour. Its tower stands 41 metres tall and was built from locally quarried stone by the engineer Edwin Thorncastle.

The original lamp burned colza oil and was visible for eleven nautical miles on a clear night. A clockwork rotation gave the light its distinctive pattern of two flashes every twelve seconds.

Electrification and the Fog Signal

Electric light replaced the oil lamp in 1931, raising the range to eighteen nautical miles. The same year a compressed-air fog signal was installed, sounding one blast every thirty seconds in poor visibility.

The last resident keeper, Agnes Dunmore, left the station in 1968 when the light was automated. Her logbooks are held by the Marlow Maritime Society.

The Lighthouse Today

The tower was listed as a protected structure in 1992. Its lantern room is opened to visitors on the first Saturday of each month between May and September, and the former keeper's cottage houses a small museum of navigation instruments.

A solar array installed in 2015 now powers the lamp, and the light continues to show two white flashes every twelve seconds.